She nodded.

“You’ve not spoken of your parents. How long have you been without them?”

“Maman died in 1940 before the Occupation started, Papa a few years after Rose was born. She doesn’t remember him.”

“And you raised Rose after your mother passed?”

“Yes, as best I could. I should have done more for her.”

“What do you mean?”

“She had to quit school at fourteen to become a cleaner. My salary wasn’t enough to support us.”

“Well, I think you’ve done a fine job. Rose has real talent. And you’ve encouraged that.” He placed a cup with water and a brush next to the demijohns. “You both can stay here until the war ends and longer after that, if you’d like.”

“You’re very kind. But we’re a burden.”

“No. Having you both here makes me feel more at ease.”

“Why?” She thought it would be the opposite.

“We can’t guess what the future holds. But knowing that you and Rose will be here, safe . . . Never mind,” he said, “let’s get these labels on.”